

The Changeling versus The Arcadian Way

During the Sundering, fae left behind in the mortal world took on the Changeling Way rite as a way to survive in an increasingly Banal world. They understood that without a mortal body to shelter them, their fae soul would eventually wither and die in the face of the chains of mortal fear and stagnancy. The Changeling Way allowed fae souls to also be reborn again and again, an unbroken chain of magic through the generations, preserved by their bond with humankind.

When the doors burst open from Arcadia once again, the sidhe who came back to Concordia discovered that they too would have to face a thoroughly Banal Autumn world by taking on mortal bodies. Yet instead of embracing the Changeling Way, these Arcadian sidhe refused to bond with a mortal body like their commoner cousins. Instead, the Arcadians chose to seek out mortal hosts and rip out the mortal souls inside. This marks them as wholly different from the sidhe of Houses Scathach and Liam, who stayed during the Shattering, and instead are reborn alongside the other kiths. Many newly-returned sidhe have also chosen to take up the Changeling Way rite, and a generation of newl-dubbed Autumn sidhe have been reborn in the mortal world. This has led to harsh criticism of the Arcadians, whose potential destruction of the human soul has been seen as unnecessary, a product of the nobility's inability to change.

society, and everything else she needs to know to survive. She also learns more about her *kith* (or faerie race), and explores her true nature surrounded by her fellow *Kithain* who can understand what she is going through.

During this time, an older changeling with more experience may offer to *foster* the new fledgling, offering to become their mentor, guardian, and teacher during the early learning period of the changeling's new life. The term fosterage comes from the medieval practice, where nobles would take on the children of another family to cement alliances or to build connections between noble children for the next generation. The mentor and fledgling swear the Oath of Fosterage, introducing the new changeling to the power of the oathbond in fae society, and linking the two together in this crucial period of growth. Since the changeling's mortal family couldn't possibly understand what the changeling is going through, fosterage offers guidance that is key for new fae in their early days.

Often, the nobility or local leadership assigns a mentor they believe has the wisdom and experience, should the fledgling be brought to the nobility upon discovery. Should a group of commoners, known as a *motley*, find the new fae, they might keep the changeling and handle the fosterage themselves,

picking a mentor from among their ranks. This mentor acts less as oathbound ward and foster and more like a big brother or sister, teaching informally as they go.

Should a changeling be discovered later in life, having gone through the Chrysalis in adulthood, the fostering period is a little different. The adult changeling becomes less of a ward and more like a guest, with her mortal life experience taken into account during her education. A mentor or several friendly teachers during this period are also key for the new adult changeling, as the radical shift from adult mortal to newly-discovered fae can be even more jarring.

The bond between the mentor and the new changeling during this time period is one of the most important in a fae's life. Fosterage at this vulnerable stage in a fae's life influences the way the changeling sees and interprets all of Kithain society. Lost in this new world, a changeling may cling to her mentor's lessons and pattern herself after them, creating a close bond that can last a lifetime. She can also rebel depending on her own nature, causing strife between the two. As the fledgling learns more about herself, a Seelie mentor might find himself teaching an Unseelie, and perhaps unruly, pupil. Still, unless major strife occurs, the bond of fosterage represents a chance for the new changeling to begin again in her new life with some stability, even family. It isn't uncommon for mentors to take in a fledgling who has had to leave her mortal kin, or for a mentor to make her ward the heir to whatever he owns. It's for this reason that the Oath of Fosterage should be carefully considered by both potential mentor and student before the decision is made, as the responsibilities may last more than just one lifetime.

The term of fosterage, while important, is not long. It is important for a new changeling to learn the ropes quickly and adapt to her new power as fast as possible. Too much can go wrong should a fledgling stay out of control in her early days, and the responsibility to keep a fledgling in check is a great burden on a mentor. Once a fledgling has adapted, however, she passes from her fosterage into the next period of her fae life. She will take the lessons from her mentor forward, spending the rest of her days honing what she has learned.

The Saining

New Kithain are given a period of adjustment during which they have time to learn their role in fae society. Under the direction of their guardian or a motley, the changeling spends this period learning about her kith, her place in court structure, and the ways of the Kithain. The period usually lasts for a year and a day, split into *the time of warding* and *the time of watching*.

In the first half, the time of warding, a new fledgling is given more leeway in her actions, as guardians teach her while taking responsibility for any accidents or mistakes the fledgling makes. The fledgling has the room to learn about customs and traditions without reprisals should they err. That changes during the time of watching, when the fledgling must apply the lessons she's learned and take responsibility for her own actions. Adult fledglings are held to an even higher standard, as it is expected